
Introduction

As shown in the image below, a transdisciplinary process is roughly divided into three phases:

- Exploring the problem
- Defining the problem
- Solving the problem and disseminating results

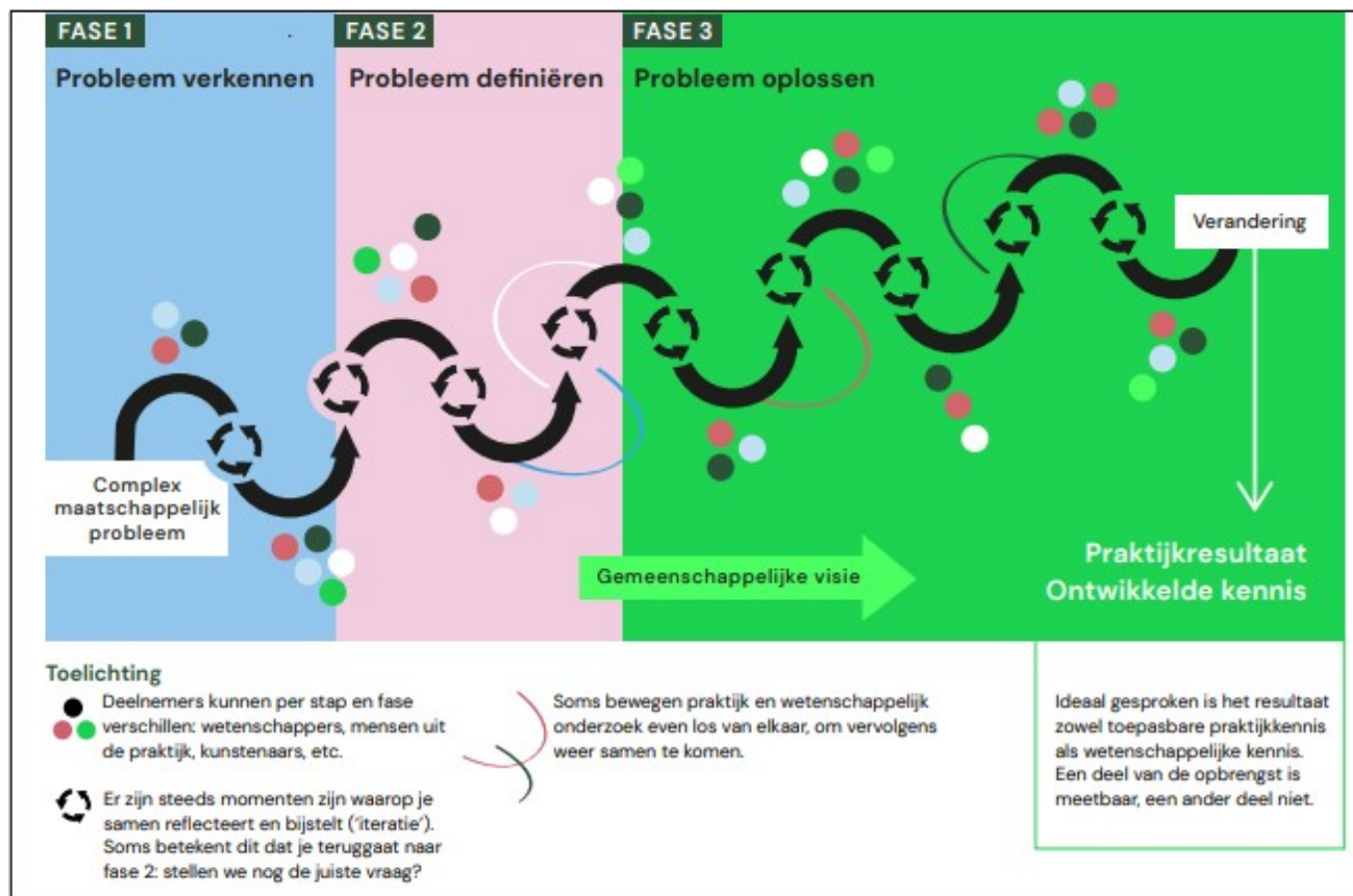
(Mauser et al., 2013)

The **Theory** page delves deeper into these three phases, including the actions and guiding questions associated with each.

Under the **Practice** tab, we present the **Co-Design Canvas**: a tool for facilitating processes in which teams work on complex challenges together.

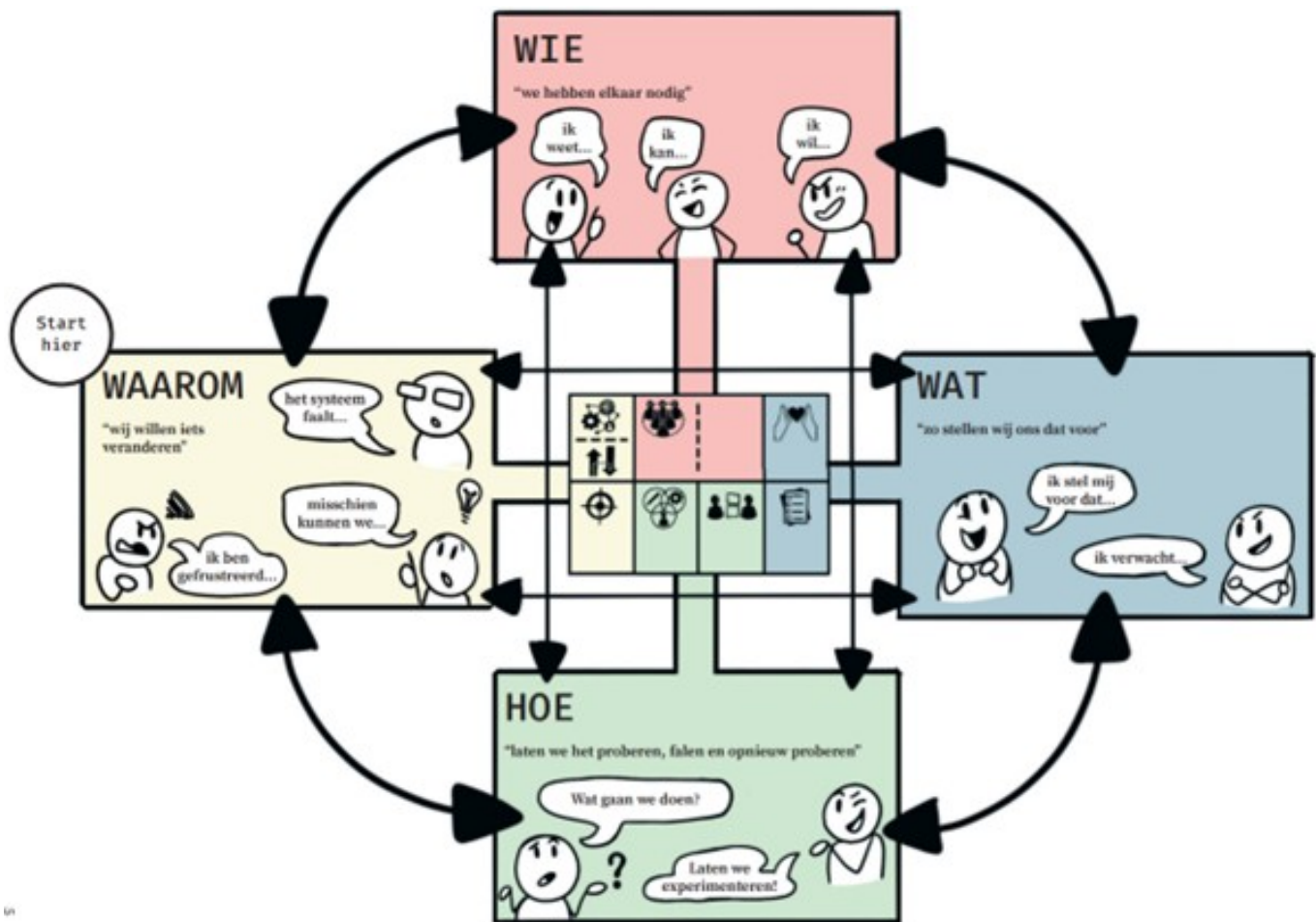
Note: Some authors of the TRAIL tool are currently working on a review study of transdisciplinary collaborations. Knowledge from this study will be added here soon.

You can already check out an introduction to this new research and the researchers here: [Scoping review transdisciplinaire samenwerkingen | Avans Hogeschool](#) **Sign up for the TRAIL newsletter** to stay informed about content updates!



Three phases of a transdisciplinary proces (Het Groene Brein, 2023).

Theory



The Co-Design Proces from the Co-Design Canvas (Smeenk, 2023)

The [co-design canvas by Smeenk \(2023\)](#) was developed as a tool to facilitate processes in which teams collaboratively create solutions for complex challenges. It supports:

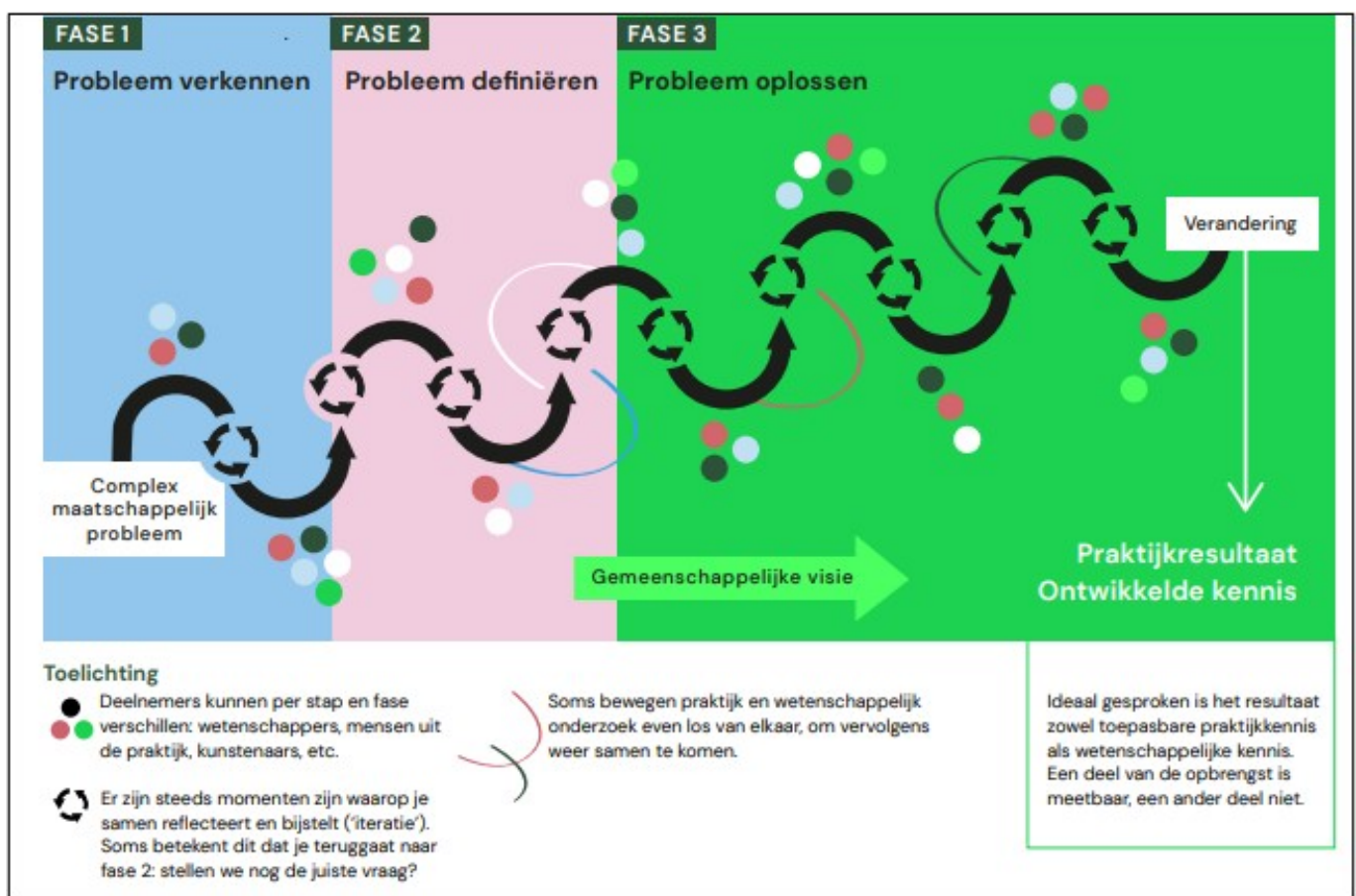
- Collaboration among team members
- Involvement of stakeholders
- Structuring and documenting the process

- Communicating ideas and workflows

Reference:

Smeenck, W. (2023). *The Co-Design Canvas 2023*. InHolland University of Applied Sciences.

Practice



Three Phases of a Transdisciplinary Process (Het Groene Brein, 2023)

The **Practical Guide to Transdisciplinary Work** (Het Groene Brein, 2023) identifies three phases in a transdisciplinary process (see image above):

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1. Exploring the problem
 2. Defining the problem
 3. Solving the problem and disseminating results

(Mauser et al., 2013)

Getting to Know Each Other and the Problem

In **Phase 1**, you explore collaboration with your team members and the problem you'll be working on together (Oskam, 2023). You want to get to know each other and understand the issue at hand.

Key questions to ask:

- Who are the problem owners?
- Who is needed to implement the solutions?
- Who will be affected by the potential solutions?

Think broadly — consider artists, animals, or nature. Take enough time to get to know each other and clarify expectations. A shared understanding of the problem is the most important foundation.

Getting to know your topic starts with mapping out the different perspectives on the issue. This helps you understand the impact of the problem and define its boundaries. Identify the facts and explore how the problem is experienced.

Defining the Problem

Based on insights from the previous phase, you now formulate the problem definition together. Make sure this is a truly **shared definition**, not just based on your own view or experience. Focus on common ground rather than differences.

Solving the Problem and Disseminating Results

In **Phase 3**, you work on solutions, insights, and a deeper understanding of the problem. Keep in mind that the results of a transdisciplinary project are not always easily measurable. Sometimes you'll achieve concrete outcomes, but in other cases, the results may be less visible. Regularly reflect on the process and outcomes together — and celebrate interim results as a team.